

'An obvious issue of academic freedom': B.C. university suspends professor for year over Facebook post

Derek Pyne said the post praised Ontario's Brock University Faculty Association for supporting Tomas Hudlicky, a professor also at the centre of controversy

National Post

Jul 22, 2020

https://nationalpost.com/news/an-obvious-issue-of-academic-freedom-b-c-university-suspends-professor-for-year-over-facebook-post/wcm/a7ccf241-fb67-4845-8bed-2360e2fbbed01/?fbclid=IwAR1apl_vR38gXA0nXbye4W8vYFanwj2YibHnyFJXKgyaw6m_pzg7f7idkFg



Thompson Rivers University professor Derek Pyne said the two complainants told TRU that being tagged in his Facebook post led to them losing sleep and one said she needed time off to recover. KAMLOOPS THIS WEEK

By Jonathan Bradley

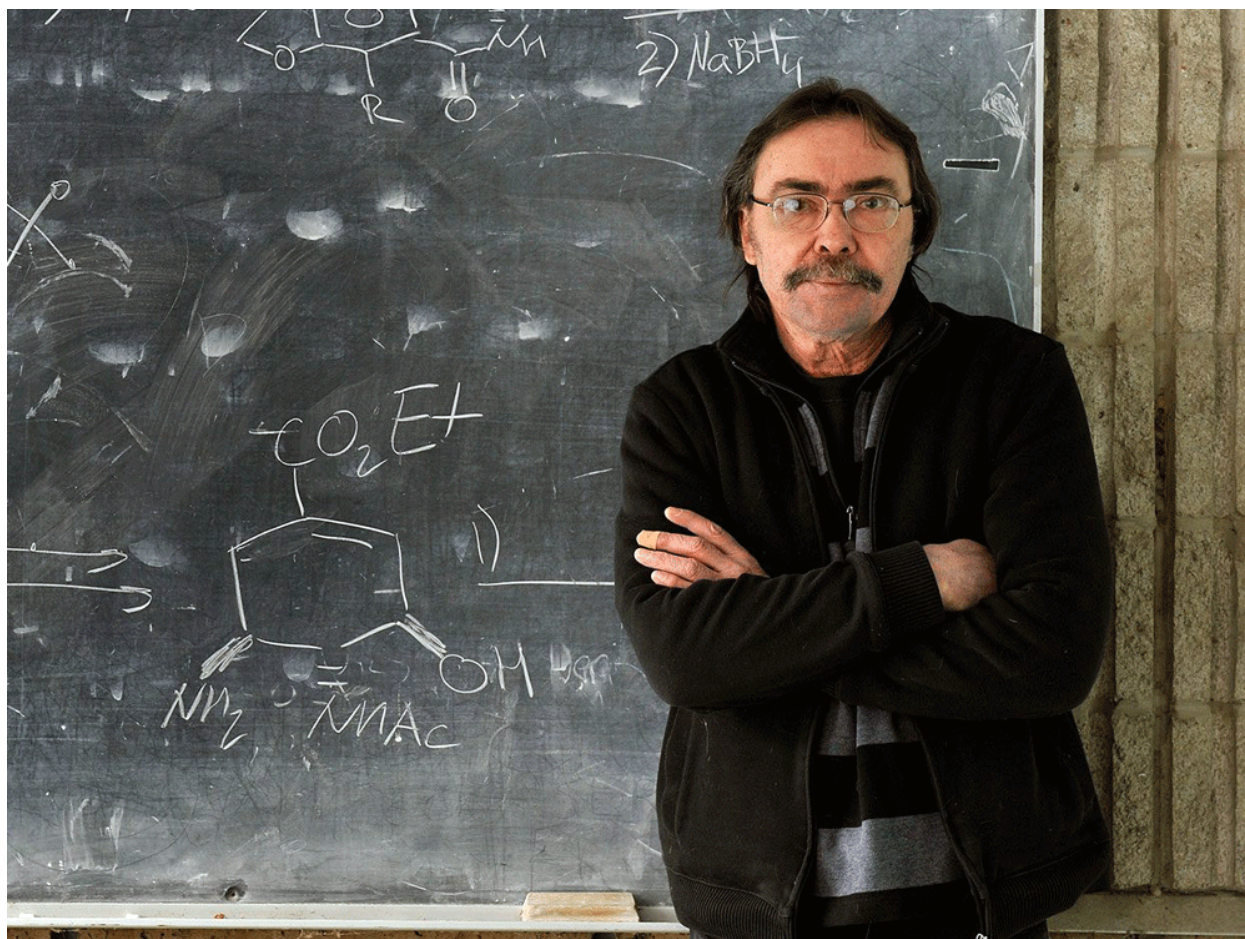
A Canadian economics professor at the centre of what he says is a battle over academic freedom has been suspended for a year because of a Facebook post.

It is the second time that Derek Pyne, of Thompson Rivers University, in Kamloops, B.C., has been suspended over the issue of academic freedom. An investigation found the first suspension in 2018 breached his academic freedom and was critical of the university.

"I was surprised," Pyne said in an interview this week. "However, at the time, I did not think that even TRU would be foolish enough to go after me for such an obvious issue of academic freedom, given how much bad publicity they generated when they attacked my academic freedom in the past."

Pyne said the suspension was over a Facebook post he made on June 10 praising Ontario's Brock University Faculty Association (BUFA) for standing up for academic freedom. The BUFA published a statement supporting Tomas Hudlicky, a chemistry professor who is also at the centre of controversy.

In a mostly technical essay in the chemistry journal *Angewandte Chemie*, Hudlicky criticized employment equity hiring and also commented on the skills transfer between "masters and apprentices."



Brock University professor Tomas Hudlicky. BROCK UNIVERSITY

The piece attracted criticism and the journal retracted the essay. Brock University issued an apology and said in a statement that the essay did not reflect the values of the university.

In his Facebook post, Pyne applauded the action of the faculty association which he said holds a divergent view from the Thompson Rivers University Faculty Association (TRUFA).

"Some good news for a change," he said in the Facebook post. "Unlike Thompson Rivers University Faculty Association, it seems that some university unions are not opposed to academic freedom. One can debate some of the details of the following statement, but the bottom line is that it comes out in support of academic freedom, even when it goes against the university, and the union's positions."

He tagged the Federation of Post-Secondary Educators and TRUFA members in a comment. He also predicted that TRUFA members would “go running” to Larry Phillips, the executive director of human resources at TRU, to defend them.

Later, at a human resources meeting, Phillips told Pyne there had been a harassment complaint against him. Pyne said the two complainants told TRU that being tagged in the post led to them losing sleep and one of them claimed she needed time off work to recover.

He has received a one-year suspension with no pay and no benefits. He has also been cut off from his TRU email account which he says contains information he requires.

Pyne said he is unsure about his next steps. He said appealing his suspension through his union makes little sense since it was a union executive member and steward who filed the complaint that led to his suspension.

Pyne was previously suspended in 2018 for writing an article in the University of Toronto Press that raised questions about professors who publish research in predatory journals. Predatory journals are outlets where professors pay to have their work published and not have them peer reviewed.



"We want to be clear that matters involving Dr. Pyne are not about the exercise of academic freedom," a spokesperson for Thompson Rivers University, said in a statement. HANDOUT/THOMPSON RIVERS UNIVERSITY/FILE

An investigation into his suspension by the Canadian Association of University Teachers completed in November found the university's administration breached his academic freedom as well as his privacy. It recommended the university review its human-resources practices to ensure academic freedom was properly understood and protected.

Pyne was later allowed to return to the university.

Darshan Lindsay, a spokesperson for TRU, said in a statement that Pyne's suspension was not about academic freedom.

"In situations where faculty members have faced discipline, it is not about their academic freedom but rather other issues that have arisen in the workplace," said Lindsay's statement.

"While we cannot provide specific information on personnel matters due to employment and privacy laws, we want to be clear that matters involving Dr. Pyne are not about the exercise of academic freedom."

I did not think that even TRU would be foolish enough to go after me for such an obvious issue of academic freedom

Lindsay said TRU employees have various avenues for appeals on employment matters by filing grievances with their union or going to the British Columbia Labour Relations Board.

Following his first suspension, Christine Bovis-Cnossen, the university's then interim president, said she was unable to comment on the reason's for Pyne's discipline. She added, "But I do want to be clear, to set the record straight, that academic freedom is fully protected at TRU."

Pyne said universities need to respect academic freedom.

"I think that the public has a right to know how tax dollars are being misused by a public institution," he said. "More generally, I think academic freedom is essential for the advancement of knowledge."